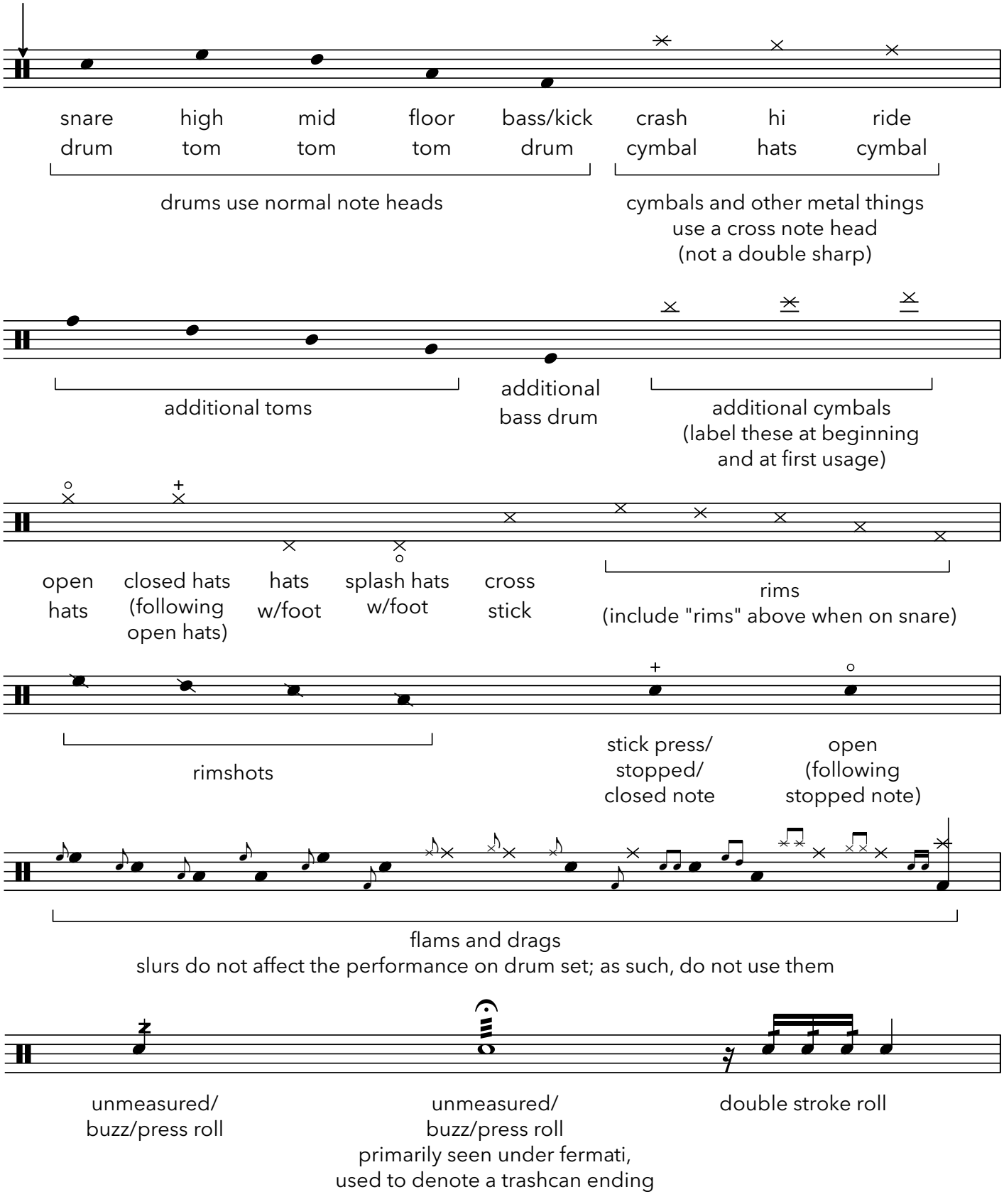
Pocket Guide To
Drum Set Notation

Courtney McNally



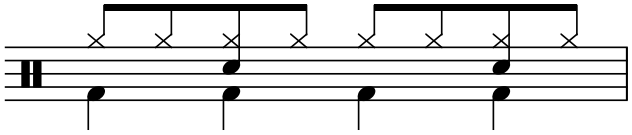
Notating Grooves

default to everything in one voice with stems up for clarity.

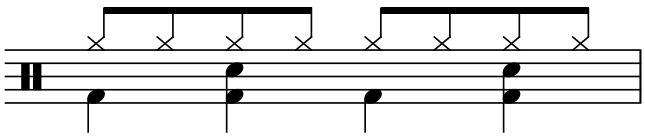
WRONG



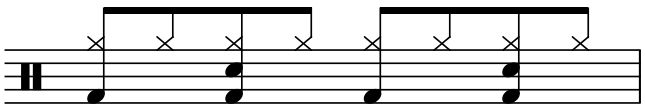
GOOD-follows body's natural division



USE RARELY AND UPON CONSULTATION

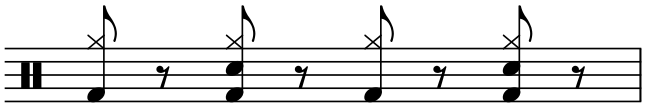


BEST-one instrument

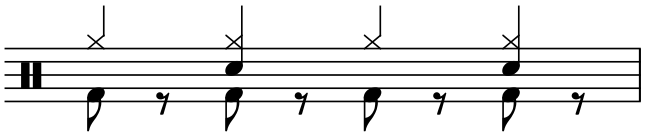


note lengths should be convenient to read. do not attempt to reflect the brevity of the instrument by using short note values that make rhythms difficult to read

WRONG



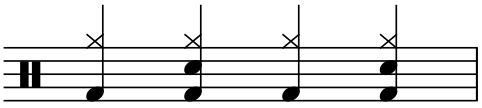
NO



ABSOLUTELY NOT



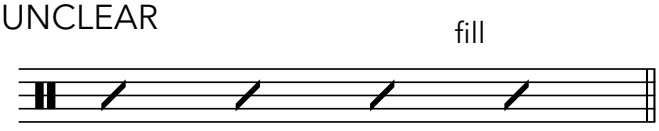
RIGHT



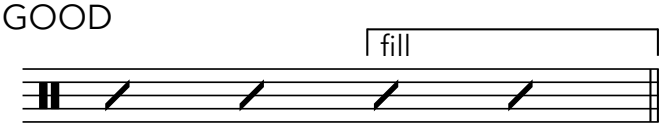
Notating Fills

be specific--either in location, rhythm, or even down to the orchestration

UNCLEAR



GOOD



GOOD



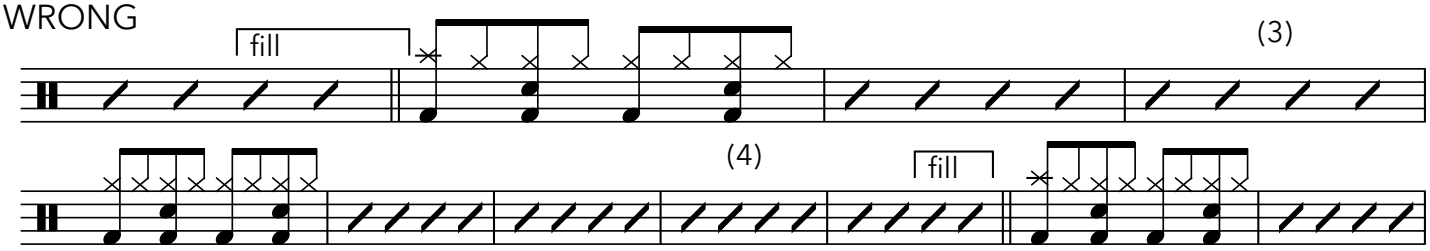
GOOD



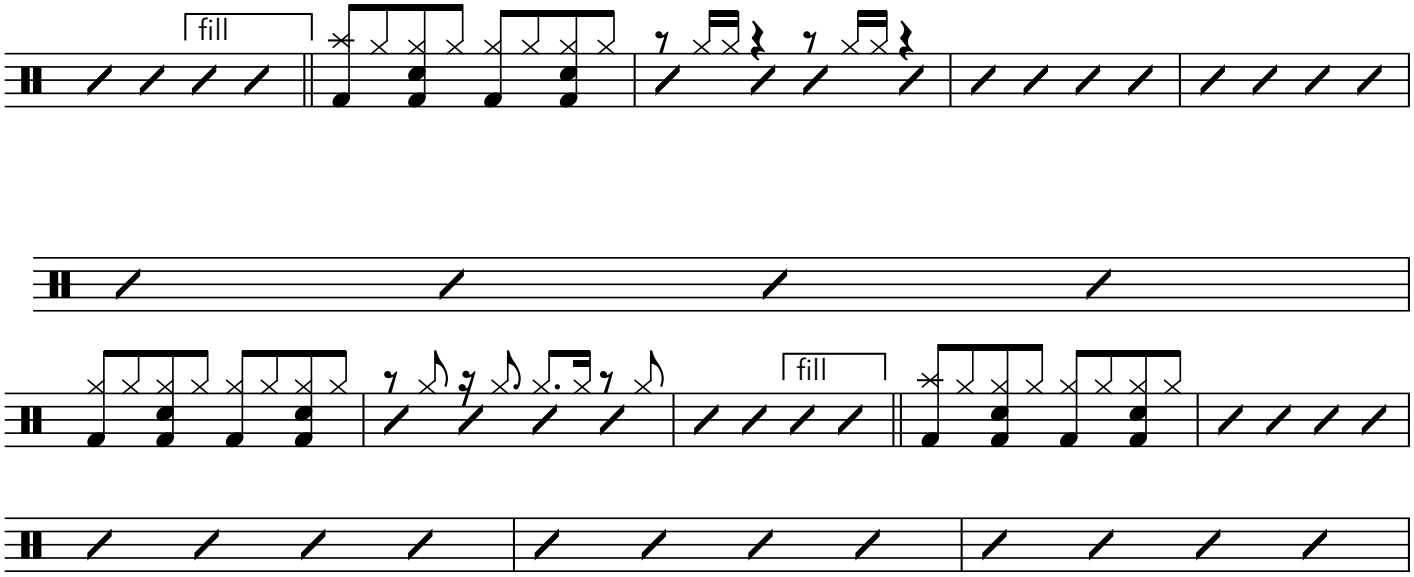
Notating Parts

when using slashes to indicate a similar idea, mark the form with numbers every two or four bars to help the musician keep track of the form. note that these numbers are keeping track of the *phrase*, not the number of measures played since the figure was notated. additionally, use line breaks to highlight the form (often 4 or 8 bar phrases)

WRONG



YOU'RE RISKING PRECIOUS REHEARSAL TIME



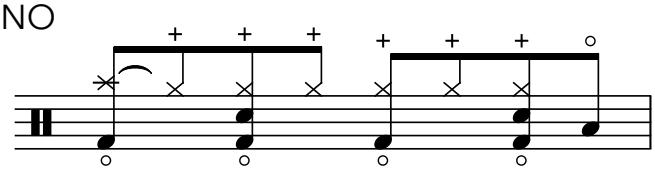
GOOD



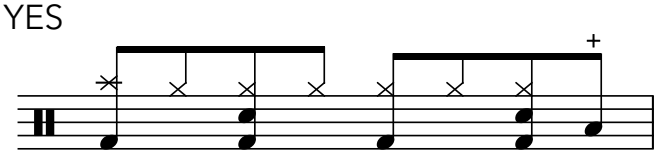
Articulations and Dynamics

all parts of the drum set are assumed to be l.v.; as such, only notate when they are not

NO

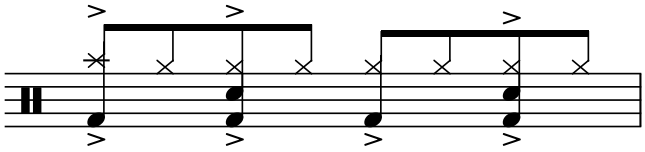


YES

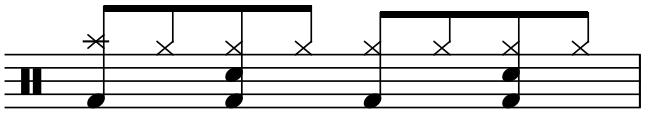


idiomatic groove playing includes "mixing" the dynamics of the kit by the player to stylistically match the genre; writing the natural mixing of the instrument in is unnecessary

WASTEFUL



GOOD



Cues vs. Hits

cues are used to show optional figures played by other sections of the ensemble. these should be cue-sized and on or floating above the staff without ledger lies, showing the full value of the measure

BAD

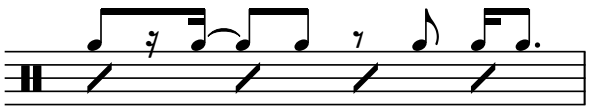


SICK HI HAT PATTERN. NO.

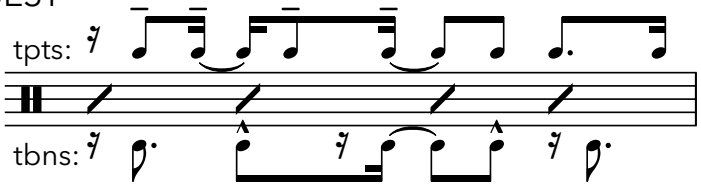


including instrumentation and articulations helps the performer orchestrate the cues

GOOD



BEST



rhythmic notation is used to indicate mandatory hits. these are always on the center line. while orchestration can be determined via knowledge of the style, articulations are occasionally useful, especially when breaking from the style

GOOD



GOOD

